The Travel Planning Checklist

The Complete Pre-Departure Guide with Packing Lists, Documents, and Budget Templates

Empire Rewards — Free Edition

INTRODUCTION

42% of travelers forget at least one essential item on every trip. The replacement costs add up fast — a forgotten phone charger, an over-the-counter medication, or a spare pair of glasses can cost $30–$200 when bought at airport or tourist-area prices.

But the bigger cost isn't what you forget. It's what you don't prepare. Missing visa requirements, expired passports, unbooked transfers, or inadequate travel insurance can turn a dream trip into an expensive disaster.

A simple pre-trip checklist prevents all of these problems for the cost of 30 minutes of your time.

This guide gives you:

- The 6-week pre-departure countdown
- A complete packing checklist (150+ items)
- A document and visa tracker
- A budget planning template
- A daily itinerary planner
- Emergency contacts and travel insurance framework
- Home preparation checklist

The checklist is modular. You don't fill out every item — you check off the ones relevant to your trip. Beach vacation? Skip the winter gear. Business trip? Skip the camping list.

Let's begin.

PART 1: THE 6-WEEK PRE-DEPARTURE COUNTDOWN

Start 4–6 weeks before departure for stress-free preparation. Here's the week-by-week breakdown.

Week 6 Before — Book & Confirm

- Book flights and accommodation
- Apply for visas if needed
- Check passport expiration (must be valid 6+ months past your return date)
- Book any special experiences (tours, restaurants, shows)
- Reserve airport parking or transportation

Week 4 Before — Health & Insurance

- Purchase travel insurance
- Schedule any required vaccinations
- Refill prescriptions for the full trip + extra
- Research local health requirements
- Download offline maps and translation apps
- Set up an international phone plan or eSIM

Week 2 Before — Prep Home & Pack

- Arrange house/pet sitters
- Hold mail or redirect packages
- Notify bank and credit card companies of travel dates
- Start laying out items to pack
- Buy any missing travel essentials now
- Scan all important documents

Week 1 Before — Finalize

- Print all confirmations and copies of documents
- Pack suitcases (leave one outfit in carry-on)
- Charge all electronics
- Set up travel notifications on banking apps
- Confirm transportation to/from airport
- Check the weather forecast for your destination

Day Before — Last Checks

- Check in for your flight (24 hours in advance)
- Confirm hotel check-in times

- Set up out-of-office email
- Empty fridge of perishables
- Lock all windows and doors
- Set thermostat
- Share final itinerary with someone you trust

Departure Day — Essentials Only

Phone, wallet, passport, boarding pass, medications, house keys, and a charged portable charger. That's all you truly need in your hands until you reach the airport.

PART 2: THE COMPLETE PACKING CHECKLIST

Documents & Money

- □

  Passport (6+ months validity)
- □

  Visa or e-visa printout
- □

  Travel insurance policy
- □

  Photocopies of all documents
- □

  Backup passport photos
- □

  Credit/debit cards (2+)
- □

  Local currency for arrival
- □

  Emergency cash (hidden in luggage)
- □

Bank travel notification set

Electronics

- □

  Universal power adapter
- □

  Portable charger (10,000mAh+)
- □

  Charging cables (2+)
- □

  Headphones or earbuds
- □

  Phone with offline maps downloaded
- □

  E-reader or tablet
- □

  Waterproof phone pouch
- □

  Camera + memory card
- □

  Backup memory card

Health & Comfort

- □

  Prescription medications
- □

  Copies of prescriptions
- □

  Basic first aid kit (bandages, pain reliever, antihistamine)
- □

- □ Sunscreen SPF 50+
- □ Insect repellent
- □ Melatonin for jet lag
- □ Reusable water bottle
- □ Neck pillow + eye mask
- □ Motion sickness tablets
- □ Lip balm and moisturizer

Clothing (Basic)

- □ Underwear (trip days + 2)
- □ Socks (trip days + 2)
- □ Tops (mix of casual + 1 dressy)
- □ Bottoms (2–3 pairs)
- □ Lightweight jacket
- □ Comfortable walking shoes
- □ Sleepwear
- □ Swimsuit (if applicable)

- □

  Rain jacket or umbrella

International Extras

- □

  Travel adapter (check plug type)
- □

  International SIM card or eSIM
- □

  Currency exchange notes
- □

  Customs declaration tips
- □

  Embassy contact info saved
- □

  Language translation app

Home Prep

- □

  Hold mail or redirect packages
- □

  Set light timers or smart plugs
- □

  Water plants or arrange plant-sitter
- □

  Share itinerary with emergency contact
- □

  Lock all windows and doors
- □

  Empty fridge of perishables

- □

  Adjust thermostat to save energy
- □

  Take out the trash
- □

  Unplug unused electronics

Carry-On Only (Never Checked)

- □

  Passport
- □

  Wallet
- □

  Phone
- □

  Boarding pass
- □

  Medications (never check)
- □

  Portable charger
- □

  One outfit change
- □

  House keys

PART 3: THE DOCUMENT & VISA TRACKER

Use this template to track all your travel documents. Update expiration dates 6 months before they expire.

Passport Tracker

Name	Passport #	Issue Date	Expiration Date	Renewal Reminder
				6 months before expiration
				6 months before expiration
				6 months before expiration
				6 months before expiration

Important passport rule: Most countries require your passport to be valid for at least 6 months beyond your return date. Check the specific requirements for your destination.

Visa Tracker

Country	Visa Type	Application Status	Applied Date	Expected Decision	Visa #	Expiration

Travel Insurance Tracker

Provider	Policy #	Coverage Type	Emergency Phone	Policy Document Saved
				☐
				☐

Booking Confirmations

Type	Provider	Confirmation #	Date	Notes

Type	Provider	Confirmation #	Date	Notes
Flight				
Flight (return)				
Hotel				
Rental car				
Tours				
Restaurant reservations				
Airport transfer				

Pro tip: Print two copies of every confirmation. Keep one in your carry-on and one in your checked luggage.

PART 4: THE BUDGET PLANNING TEMPLATE

Track your travel spending with estimated vs. actual columns. Here's the structure.

Sample Budget (7-Day International Trip)

Category	Estimated	Actual	Notes
Flights	$1,200		
Accommodation	$700		
Airport transfers	$80		
Local transport	$100		
Food & dining	$400		

Category	Estimated	Actual	Notes
Activities	$300		
Souvenirs	$150		
Travel insurance	$60		
SIM card / data	$30		
Miscellaneous	$150		
Total	**$3,170**		

How to Use the Template

1. **Research actual prices** before you travel. Look up flights, hotels, and typical meal costs for your destination.
2. **Add 15% buffer** to your estimated total for unexpected costs.
3. **Track daily spending** while traveling. Update the actual column each evening.
4. **Compare at the end** of the trip to improve your estimates next time.

Group Trip Split Calculator

If you're traveling with others, use this simple structure:

Expense	Total	Paid By	Split Between	Per Person
Hotel (4 nights)	$600	Sarah	3 people	$200
Rental car	$240	Mike	3 people	$80
Group dinner	$180	Alex	3 people	$60
Totals	**$1,020**			**$340 each**

Use a payment app (Venmo, Splitwise, Wise) to settle up at the end.

PART 5: THE DAILY ITINERARY PLANNER

Use this template for each day of your trip. Print one page per day.

Day ___ of ___

Date: _____
City: _____

Morning (8am–12pm)

- Activity: _____
- Address: _____
- Confirmation #: _____
- Cost: _____

Lunch (12pm–2pm)

- Restaurant: _____
- Address: _____
- Reservation: _____
- Cost: _____

Afternoon (2pm–6pm)

- Activity: _____
- Address: _____
- Confirmation #: _____
- Cost: _____

Dinner (6pm–9pm)

- Restaurant: _____
- Address: _____
- Reservation: _____
- Cost: _____

Evening (9pm+)

- Activity: _____
- Address: _____
- Cost: _____

Backup Activities (in case of rain, closures, or cancellations)

- _____
- _____

Notes

- Local emergency number: _____
- Hotel address (in local language): _____
- Weather forecast: _____

PART 6: THE EMERGENCY CONTACTS SHEET

Fill this in for every trip. Keep one printed copy in your wallet and one saved in your phone.

Destination Contacts

Embassy (destination country):

- Country: _____
- Address: _____
- Phone: _____
- Email: _____
- Hours: _____

Local Emergency Numbers:

- Police: _____
- Ambulance: _____
- Fire: _____
- Tourist police: _____

Personal Contacts

Emergency Contact at Home:

- Name: _____
- Relationship: _____
- Phone: _____
- Email: _____

Secondary Emergency Contact:

- Name: _____
- Relationship: _____
- Phone: _____

- Email: _____

Insurance & Medical

Travel Insurance Emergency Line:

- Provider: _____
- Policy #: _____
- Phone: _____
- Claims email: _____

Doctor at Home (for non-emergency consults):

- Name: _____
- Phone: _____
- Notes: _____

PART 7: THE TRAVEL INSURANCE FRAMEWORK

What to Look For

Coverage	Minimum Recommendation	Why It Matters
Medical	$100,000+	Hospital stays, doctor visits, emergency care
Medical Evacuation	$250,000+	Air ambulance, emergency transport home
Trip Cancellation	100% of trip cost	Reimbursement if you can't travel
Trip Interruption	150% of trip cost	Reimbursement if you cut the trip short
Baggage Loss	$1,000+	Lost or delayed luggage reimbursement
24/7 Emergency Line	Included	Real humans in any time zone

Common Exclusions

- Pre-existing medical conditions

- Extreme sports and adventure activities (paragliding, scuba, etc.)
- Travel to countries with active travel warnings
- Alcohol or drug-related incidents
- Intentional damage or negligence

How to File a Claim

1. Document everything — take photos, keep receipts
2. Get written statements from anyone involved (police, hotel, airline)
3. Submit the claim within 30 days of the incident
4. Include your policy number, proof of purchase, and supporting documents
5. Follow up every 2 weeks until resolved

When to Buy Travel Insurance

Buy as soon as you book your trip. This gives you the maximum coverage window for cancellations. Waiting until the last minute limits your cancellation coverage and may cost more.

PART 8: SMART TRAVEL TIPS

The "One Outfit in Your Carry-On" Rule

Always pack one complete change of clothes in your carry-on bag. If your checked luggage is delayed (which happens on roughly 1 in 150 flights), you'll have something clean to wear while you sort things out.

Local SIM vs. International Roaming

In most countries, a local prepaid SIM card is 5–10x cheaper than international roaming. Research local SIM options before you arrive. Many airports have SIM card kiosks in the arrivals hall. Alternatively, eSIM services let you activate a local data plan before you land.

The Photo-First Insurance Claim

If you need to make a travel insurance claim — for lost luggage, delayed flights, or stolen items — photographic evidence dramatically speeds up the process. Photograph your packed luggage before departure, keep receipts for all purchases abroad, and screenshot any delay notifications from your airline.

Scan Everything Before You Go

Scan your passport, visa, insurance policy, and any important documents. Email the scans to yourself and save them in cloud storage. If your physical documents get lost or stolen, you'll have everything you need to get replacements quickly.

Split Your Money

Never keep all your cash and cards in one place. Split cash between a wallet, a money belt, and a hidden pocket in your luggage. Keep one credit card separate from the others.

The "Two Copies" Rule

Print two copies of every important document — one for your carry-on, one for your checked luggage. If one goes missing, you have a backup.

The 3-Hour Rule for Layovers

Flights with 3–6 hour layovers are often 30–50% cheaper than direct flights. Pack a book, find a quiet gate, and use the time productively.

Consider Nearby Airports

Flying into a secondary airport can save significant money:

- Oakland instead of San Francisco
- Stansted instead of Heathrow
- Beauvais instead of Charles de Gaulle
- Treviso instead of Venice Marco Polo

Set Price Alerts

Before you book, set price alerts on Google Flights, Skyscanner, or Hopper. They'll notify you when prices drop on your route.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

What is included in the travel planning checklist?

The checklist includes a complete packing list organized by category, a document and visa tracker, a budget planning template, a daily itinerary planner, an emergency contacts sheet, and a travel insurance comparison guide. All items are printable and customizable.

Can I customize the checklist for different types of trips?

Yes, the checklist is designed to be flexible. It includes sections for beach vacations, city breaks, business travel, backpacking, and family trips. You can add or remove items based on your destination, trip length, and travel style.

Does the travel planner include a packing list for international travel?

Yes, the packing list includes specific items for international travel including passport and visa requirements, travel adapter guides, currency exchange notes, international SIM card reminders, and customs declaration tips.

Is the travel budget template suitable for group trips?

The budget template supports both solo and group travel planning. It includes expense categories for accommodation, transport, food, activities, and miscellaneous costs, with columns for estimated vs. actual spending and a per-person split calculator for group trips.

How far in advance should I start using the travel planner?

For best results, start 4–6 weeks before your trip. The planner includes a pre-departure countdown checklist that breaks tasks into weekly milestones.

Is this checklist useful for weekend trips?

Yes. For weekend trips, you can focus on the packing essentials and documents sections only. The itinerary planner works equally well for a 2-day city break or a 3-week adventure.

Do I really need travel insurance?

Yes, if you're traveling internationally. Medical emergencies abroad can cost $10,000–$100,000+ without coverage. Basic travel insurance costs $20–$100 per trip. It's the single most important purchase for any international trip.

CONCLUSION

You now have:

- The 6-week pre-departure countdown
- The complete packing checklist (150+ items)
- A document and visa tracker
- A budget planning template with group split calculator
- A daily itinerary planner
- Emergency contacts sheet
- Travel insurance framework
- 8 smart travel tips

The only thing left is to start. Print the checklists. Fill them in. Follow the countdown.

By departure day, everything will be ready — and you'll be able to enjoy the trip instead of worrying about what you forgot.

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